swamplands, it did not lose power for two days. It wreaked destruction leading to the loss of 65 per cent of Burma's rice fields and 95 per cent of the buildings in the delta region.[3] In addition, the Irrawaddy flooded for up to 50 km from the coast, causing widespread damage. The economic dislocation was profound and it has been estimated that up to 138,000 people lost their lives.

The regime acted predictably. It initially refused to ask for help and it was not until 9 May (a week after the cyclone struck) that it agreed to accept the aid on offer. Initially only ASEAN members were allowed in but, after pressure from the UN, by 23 May the regime agreed that other international aid organisations would be allowed to help. As discussed above, there was a degree of military threat[4] involved in forcing this decision, with especially the French arguing that the regime was becoming a danger to its own people.[5] Even as it was, reluctantly, accepting aid, the regime was still exporting rice to pay for weapons and to earn foreign currency. Equally, the regime initially tried to control the distribution of aid to those it saw as loyal supporters.[6]

The regime's response was poor for a number of reasons. At its core, the army had long been an instrument of domestic repression and was ill-suited to helping the people of Myanmar. However, the Irrawaddy Delta is also home to part of the Karen ethnic group, who have been in revolt against Burmese rule since the 1960s. Thus the army's natural disposition to see civilians as their enemies was worsened due to the hostility of many in the region. Equally, while cyclones are normal, the most destructive usually hit Bangladesh, and the Myanmar regime was unprepared for the worst storm to hit the country for generations.

The conspicuous absence of the military when they were needed to help was in contrast to their overbearing presence during the violence of the repression of the uprising in 2007. Civilians in Rangoon started to ask: 'where are all those uniformed people who are always ready to beat monks and civilians? They should come out in full force and help clean up the area and restore electricity'.[7] Overall, this mismanagement of the crisis further reduced the legitimacy of the regime in the eyes of the population, and perhaps contributed to pressure that forced the military to allow fresh elections in 2010.